

Line Length

Many Python programmers recommend that each line should be less than 80 characters. Historically, this guideline developed because most computers could fit only 79 characters on a single line in a terminal window. Currently, people can fit much longer lines on their screens, but other reasons exist to adhere to the 79-character standard line length.

Professional programmers often have several files open on the same screen, and using the standard line length allows them to see entire lines in two or three files that are open side by side onscreen. PEP 8 also recommends that you limit all of your comments to 72 characters per line, because some of the tools that generate automatic documentation for larger projects add formatting characters at the beginning of each commented line.

The PEP 8 guidelines for line length are not set in stone, and some teams prefer a 99-character limit. Don't worry too much about line length in your code as you're learning, but be aware that people who are working collaboratively almost always follow the PEP 8 guidelines. Most editors allow you to set up a visual cue, usually a vertical line on your screen, that shows you where these limits are.

NOTE

Appendix B shows you how to configure your text editor so it always inserts four spaces each time you press the TAB key and shows a vertical guideline to help you follow the 79-character limit.

Blank Lines

To group parts of your program visually, use blank lines. You should use blank lines to organize your files, but don't do so excessively. By following the examples provided in this book, you should strike the right balance. For example, if you have five lines of code that build a list and then another three lines that do something with that list, it's appropriate to place a blank line between the two sections. However, you should not place three or four blank lines between the two sections.

Blank lines won't affect how your code runs, but they will affect the readability of your code. The Python interpreter uses horizontal indentation to interpret the meaning of your code, but it disregards vertical spacing.

Other Style Guidelines

PEP 8 has many additional styling recommendations, but most of the guidelines refer to more complex programs than what you're writing at this point. As you learn more complex Python structures, I'll share the relevant parts of the PEP 8 guidelines.